Unseasoned · Game Design Document

Takernal Game Jam 2026, theme "The food that brings us together" · Best Narrative · team of five, nine days · Andrés Ruiz Palomino (Arzpal): co-director, sole programmer, gameplay and narrative designer

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1. Pitch

One line:

> A cook who has travelled the world opens a restaurant in a grey city, and brings its colour back by listening to people and serving them exactly what they need.

For the itch.io page:

> Customers arrive from everywhere. They don't tell you what they want: they tell you how they are. Your job is to listen, ask the right questions, and figure out which dish from around the world is the one that person needs today. Every customer you get right brings colour back to a piece of the place. Nobody can fail here: just cook, and pay attention.

The hook: it is the structure of *Papers, Please* with the morality inverted. The same loop that there makes you complicit in a cruelty, here makes you complicit in a reunion.

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2. How it answers the theme

The theme has two halves and most teams only address one. "A cooking game" answers *food* but not *brings us together*.

This game answers it in **two layers**, and neither needs a line of dialogue to explain it:

1. **The menu is the thesis.** The 5 dishes are real fusions: chaufa and lomo saltado (Peru+China), tacos al pastor (Lebanese shawarma in Mexico), vindaloo (Portugal in Goa) and pizza marinara (**the tomato is American**). **Every dish is already made of two cultures that met.**
2. **The mechanic is listening.** The game is about the distance between what someone **asks for** and what someone **needs**. A waiter takes orders; a cook who knows you knows what you are missing.

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3. Core gameplay

- **Main verb: listen and deduce.** Then cook as the reward.
- **A linear, single-pass experience.**

The loop (per diner)

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1. ARRIVES      A diner walks in and sits in a dim area of the place.
2. TALKS        You ask questions. When relevant information appears, you MARK it.
                Marking opens new questions. With everything marked, you ask their name.
3. CHOOSES      The recipe book opens with the dish already pointed out and the lines you
                marked next to it. You cannot choose wrong: it is the payoff, not a test.
4. COOKS        Chained minigames. You can never fail.
5. SERVES       The diner reacts. Their area of the place TAKES ON COLOUR.
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- **Win condition:** all 5 diners served, the whole place in colour.
- **Lose condition: there is none.** See pillar 2.

4. The pillars

PILLAR	WHAT IT MEANS
Zero pressure	No money, no quota, no clock, no management. The only tension is understanding the person.
You never fail	Cooking is a ritual, not a test. The game waits for you to finish each section.
Anonymous city, specific food	The city is never named or located. The dishes are extremely concrete.
Listening > choosing	The game is in extracting the information, not in picking right from a list.
The colour comes back	Progress is seen, not read on a counter.

5. The attention dialogue

It is the heart of the game and its most distinctive mechanic. Closer to *Her Story* than to *Papers, Please*: it is not a puzzle with a right answer, it is **attention with progression**.

- The diner **does not say up front where they are from or what is wrong.**
- There are **2 opening questions**. Everything else unlocks by marking.
- **Marking a line CREATES a question derived from it**, but does not jump to it: it stays available and the player decides whether to use it. *The chef draws the information out without it showing.*
- A single answer can carry **2 marks** that open different branches.
- **Three kinds of mark:** 🔑 key (points to the dish) · useful (emotional branch) · decoy (a likeable question with no way forward; gives context but does not advance).
- **The name question closes** the conversation. It opens once every key and useful mark is found.

Where the interest comes from, when you cannot fail:

1. **The distance between asking and needing.** The value is in **understanding why** that dish is the right one.
2. **The player builds the chain.** Marking well opens the way; not marking only makes the clue wait. It feels like steering the conversation.
3. **The recipe book is a progress list**, not a decision list. Completed dishes get checked off.
4. **Every dish carries its line of origin** in the recipe book: it makes it readable why that dish heals that diner.

6. Session structure

- **5 diners** over **2 days**.
- The place starts **in black and white**. Each diner sits in a dim area; when you please them, that area **takes on colour with a fade-in**. Once lit, it stays lit. Each strip of the city lights up on its own when its diner is reconciled.

7. Menu and minigames

- **5 dishes**, all real fusions. Each one has a **signature step**.
- **9 reusable minigame types**, each with its own direct-manipulation gesture. **The cost is per step type, never per dish:** adding a dish = adding data.
- Each dish uses 3 to 5 steps. **M1 (select) always opens. M6 (plate) closes almost always:** in baked dishes you plate *before* and the oven is the last step. The marinara pizza goes `M1 → M9 → M6 → M7` on purpose, the same way a lasagne would.
- **The duration of each step is data, not code:** the same step type can last 2 seconds in one dish and be the signature step of another.

MINIGAME	WHICH DISH USES IT
M1 Select	all of them
M2 Cut	lomo saltado *(board)* · tacos al pastor *(spit)*
M3 Sauté	chaufa · lomo saltado
M4 Grind	vindaloo
M5 Pour	vindaloo · tacos al pastor
M6 Plate	all of them
M7 Cooking	chaufa *(pot)* · lomo saltado *(fryer)* · pizza *(oven)*
M9 Knead	pizza

8. Controls

Mouse only. The game is playable in WebGL with no keyboard or gamepad.

ACTION	INPUT
Pick a question / mark information	Click
Select, cut, plate, knead	Click and drag
Sauté	Flick upward
Grind / blend	Hold, or drag in circles
Pour	Drag while rotating
Lift a pot lid / raise the basket	Drag upward

9. Art direction

- **City and restaurant in grey; the food is the only saturated thing.** Colour returns by area.
- The desaturation is a shader: **the art is always drawn in colour** and the game switches it off and on.
- The city's characters **are not villains and they are not empty**: they are busy, tired and lonely.

10. Audio direction

- **An Italian base**, because of the stereotype that links Italy with food. Motivated in the fiction: **the Italian is the voice of the restaurant.**
- **The game works on mute.** Nothing critical is communicated by sound alone.

11. What the game is NOT

- **Economy management** (money, quota, rent): it contradicts the zero-pressure pillar.
- **Parallel cooking** (two things at once): it is the engine of *Overcooked* and it creates exactly the pressure the game forbids.
- **Serving couples at odds with each other:** deliberately cut; it existed to add mechanical depth, and that depth didn't buy what it cost.
- **Bespoke minigames for a single dish.**
- Map, exploration, character movement.